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Finding the Question: A Puzzle-Based Approach to the Logic of Discovery

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ABSTRACT

When it comes to research design, the literature largely focuses on prescriptions for strengthening causal inference—identifying confounders, selecting appropriately comparable cases, generating testable hypotheses, etc. This approach to research design features the logic of inquiry heavily, but overlooks the logic of discovery. The logic of discovery is a stage in the research design process that is often bracketed off as an unexplainable moment of inspiration, and is largely missing from the research design literature. We address this gap by advancing a puzzle-based approach to the discovery phase in the life cycle of a research project. We develop a typology of empirical, theoretical, and methodological puzzles, and provide guidance for identifying research questions in each. We argue that not only can the discovery phase of a research design be thought of—and taught—in a systematic way, but that a puzzle-based approach to developing research questions can structure subsequent decisions, such as case selection, identifying the appropriate theoretical framework, and concept formation. We conclude that a puzzle-based approach is a useful way to structure research design, both for practitioners and as a pedagogical tool.

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A key challenge in teaching undergraduate social science research is coaching students how to properly pose a research question. For many students, learning how to conduct research is like learning a new language. As a result, they often approach research questions in ways that do not set up the crucial next steps in creating a research design—including conceptualizing dependent variables, writing literature reviews, and developing causal arguments.

Unsuccessful research questions generally conflate *questions* with *interests* (Luker 2008). These can take several forms. For instance, students may ask “yes or no” questions, such as: *Does foreign aid make Africa worse off?* While this can help frame a research interest, it does not help develop an explanation later in the research process. Alternatively, some students are driven by normative motives, asking questions like: *Should the U.S increase foreign aid to Africa?* Although such questions help establish why a research project matters, they require further development as a set of implications for research. And, like a “yes or no” question, one cannot develop testable hypotheses

around normative questions on their own. Finally, many students pose questions that “lead with a cause.” That is, they imbue a research question with an implied hypothesis. A common example is: *How does foreign aid affect Africa?* Here, the student poses the research question upside down, guided by an independent variable and leaving the dependent variable unspecified. This habit of posing what Luker (2008) describes as “faux” research questions (53) is often the hardest to break. Repurposing the real-world events that interest students into a proper research question can be demotivating as students remain stalled between a general topic and a specific question.

Yet it is often curiosity about real-world events that draws undergraduates to the social sciences. How, then, to teach students to pose research questions and also pursue their topical interests? When it comes to research design, students tend to be socialized by methods literature that focuses on causal and descriptive inference. This dominant approach focuses primarily on the logic of inquiry. While important, this approach can overlook strategies for posing good research questions, which we propose can be found in the logic of discovery. In this article, we argue that the logic of discovery is not an unexplainable moment of inspiration, but an essential first step in the research design process. Furthermore, we claim that the way in which one selects research questions has downstream implications for other components of research design.

To fill this gap, and to help undergraduates formulate questions and learn research practices, we advance a puzzle-based approach to the discovery phase of a research project. In what follows, we distinguish the logic of discovery from the logic of inquiry. We then develop a typology of empirical, theoretical, and methodological puzzles, which provides guidance for identifying research questions. We also discuss the connection between different puzzles and later components of research design.

Logic of inquiry versus logic of discovery

During the early phases of research design, students and researchers generally orient themselves towards the logic of inquiry, which is rooted in methodological scholarship on descriptive and causal inference. This literature provides ample guidance on concept formation and measurement, case selection, cross-case analysis, and within-case analysis.¹

There is less guidance, however, on the logic of discovery, which we define here as a set of formal principles for devising a research question. For instance, Popper ([1934]2002, 7–9) showed little interest in why scientists ask the questions they do, only briefly noting that research questions are simply moments of inspiration. As such, Popper relegated the formulation of research questions to its *psychology*, rather than its *logic*. The psychology of why we ask questions, however, is not insignificant. Munck and Snyder (2008) interviewed 15 scholars of comparative politics, often asking why they asked the questions they did. The interviewees emphasized real-world events and normative concerns about how to address them (22–27). What their stories reveal are the common difficulties that arise when researchers try to link their empirical and normative interests in these events with foundational questions—big and small, old and new, “safe” and “risky” (17–19)—in ways that promote good social science research.

King, Keohane, and Verba (1994), in noting Popper's indifference, suggest two criteria for research questions: Questions should be "substantively significant," and should enable the researcher to make a contribution to an established literature (14–19). Though they devote more space than Popper to guidance in formulating research questions, they rely heavily on the researcher's prior knowledge of an established literature. Additionally, they privilege the remaining components of research design—theory, data, and analysis—and provide far more guidance on topics such as causal inference, selection bias, and measurement error.

In contrast to King, Keohane, and Verba's more theoretical slant, some scholars highlight the value of a more empirical approach. For instance, George and Bennett (2005) note that researchers can use case-study findings to bolster theory development, pointing to the utility of deviant cases for identifying novel questions, hypotheses, variables, causal paths, and causal mechanisms. Likewise, Gerring (2012) offers several suggestions for selecting research questions that are more empirically-driven, such as identifying new causal conditions of well-studied outcomes (e.g., democratization), or new causal mechanisms of established causal relationships (28–30). Still, while an empirical approach moves the researcher closer to the logic of discovery, the strategy suggested here is most often deployed in the service of inquiry.

This tendency to side-step discovery is also a feature of many textbooks aimed at undergraduates. Some textbooks advise developing research projects based on assumed student interests (Babbie 2015); others encourage connecting these interests to the appropriate literature (Lune and Berg 2004; Kellstedt and Whitten 2013; Chambliss and Schutt 2012; Barakso, Sabet, and Schaffner 2013); still others instruct students to devise questions after selecting a method (Creswell 1994). The issue that remains, however, is *how* to connect research interests to questions. Though Gerring and Christenson (2017), for example, offer strategies such as "Practice Dis-belief and Theorize Wildly" (262–271), they still note that devising research questions is "inherently unformulaic" (262).

These prevailing approaches provide a point of departure, but here we argue that they tend to be less effective when teaching undergraduates how to pose research questions. Students often enroll in political science classes because they want a better understanding of real-world events. This desire lends itself to posing research questions that are guided by empirical phenomena, even when students have limited empirical knowledge. In shifting the emphasis to the logic of discovery, we augment the approaches discussed above by developing a puzzle-based typology that can accommodate students who are interested in specific political phenomena but are neophytes when it comes to theory and methods—a problem we simultaneously address by broadening our typology to include theoretical and methodological puzzles.

Why puzzles matter

To address the concerns outlined above, we build on existing work that emphasizes the importance of puzzles in research design. Specifically, we draw upon Rosenau (1980), who defines puzzles in terms of the "perplexity over specific patterned outcomes" (17), and sees them as paths to devising research questions and building theories. Echoing this view is Zinnes' (1980) claim that puzzles are pieces of evidence believed to fit

together meaningfully, though it is unclear *how* they fit initially (316). In this vein, Gustafsson and Hagström (2017) show how to use puzzles to determine if research is “meaningful.” But where they provide a puzzle-based *justification* for research and advice on puzzle *construction*, we add to the broader discussion by providing a practical guide to *identifying* and *using* puzzles, specifically in the service of posing good research questions. We do this in two ways. First, we develop a typology of puzzles based on Shapiro’s (2002) distinction between problem-, theory-, and methods-driven research. This typology expands the terrain of puzzles in a way that synthesizes approaches to observing real-world phenomena, identifying gaps in theory, and conducting research. Second, we explore how each type of puzzle can help build other components of research design, specifically case selection, literature review, and concept formation and measurement.

Types of puzzles

In this section, we describe three types of puzzles—empirical, theoretical, and methodological—each of which is broken down into subtypes. Empirical puzzles present ways of identifying counterintuitive or varying phenomenon. And while theoretical and methodological types may be elsewhere considered *approaches*, we consider them puzzles by virtue of their fine-grained distinctions between different theoretical gaps, and by their problem-based categorization of methodology. We contend that frontloading the research process with any of these puzzles can give rise to clear research questions that set the scene for descriptive and causal inference.

Empirical puzzles

An empirical puzzle is grounded in real-world events. As such, these puzzles lend themselves to inductive research, creating the dual challenge of requiring researchers to be familiar with actual cases, and working backwards from the puzzle to find or build an appropriate theoretical framework. While empirical puzzles require some familiarity with theory or conventional wisdom, they rely primarily on a researcher’s knowledge of a case or region. For undergraduates, empirical puzzles are likely the most accessible mode of discovery as they are grounded in real-world political phenomena.

We identify three types of empirical puzzles. First, a *contra expectations* puzzle is when a phenomenon occurs against the conventional wisdom or theoretical expectations regarding everything we think we know about something. For instance, one might predict that because Ethiopia is so poor, it would experience low levels of economic growth. Yet Ethiopia, with a per capita GDP of around \$700, has one of the fastest growing economies in Africa at around 10.2% (World Bank 2017). What explains this? In another example: Prevailing theories argue that in the United States, political parties ultimately choose presidential nominees—i.e., “the party decides” (Cohen, Karol, Noel, and Zaller 2009). The nomination of Donald Trump as GOP candidate for the 2016 presidential elections defied this explanation. What, then, explains Trump?

Second, a *divergence/convergence* puzzle refers to a set of cases that do not relate to each other in an expected way. This type corresponds with the Milleen methods of

agreement and difference, but is pedagogically presented here as a puzzle to link research design more intuitively to a student's empirical observations. *Divergence* is when multiple cases that look similar experience different outcomes. For example, though Uganda's many armed groups have similar characteristics (e.g., having antigovernment grievances, getting outside resources), they met very different fates (e.g., signing peace accords, being eliminated, imploding internally; Day 2011). What explains this variation?

Convergence is when multiple cases that look very different experience the same outcome. For example, in the 1960s and 1970s, different African countries adopted different political ideologies to guide their development: capitalism, socialism, and Marxism (Young 1982). While capitalism emerged as dominant by the 1990s, no single ideology produced significantly better development outcomes than the others. Why did these very different ideologies lead to similar economic outcomes?

Finally, a third type of empirical puzzle is *variation over time*. This occurs when conditions of a political phenomenon seem stable but suddenly change. For example, there has been a recent spike in antigay politics in countries like Uganda. Such laws were features of the colonial period, but only in the past few years have political leaders become interested in re-legislating, expanding, and enforcing them (Parliament of Uganda 2009). What explains this rise? Similarly, support for marriage equality in the United States changed dramatically in the last decade. What explains this sudden swing in public opinion?

Regarding research design, students should move from the research question to case selection, concept formation, and then the literature review when working with empirical puzzles. While case selection is built into the process of identifying empirical puzzles, the challenge is finding the body of literature into which the project best fits. Students should select cases based on the research question, and then conceptualize and operationalize the outcome of interest. They can then use this to guide a literature review, building a survey of existing theories of related phenomena. Taking the above example of marriage equality, students can conceptualize swings in public opinion, look for how other scholars have explained rapid changes in public opinion, and proceed from there.

Theoretical puzzles

Theoretical puzzles are found in gaps or contradictions in existing literatures. Largely deductive, such puzzles require familiarity with a particular body of theory, and pose challenges of case selection in order to test a new theory. Learning how to identify a theoretical puzzle requires an extra dimension of sophistication for many undergraduates, and may be more suitable for graduate students.

We identify three types of theoretical puzzles. The first is *conceptual omission*, in which a body of literature only addresses one type of phenomenon, when theoretically other types of phenomena could exist. For instance, Staniland's (2010) evaluation of *urban* insurgencies notes that within the literature on civil wars, the concept of "insurgency" is limited to a certain type—rural insurgencies. So, what explains the organization and behavior of urban rebels? Another example is Fazal's (2004) work on

state death, where she notes that the conventional emphasis in international relations on state survival omits failure as an outcome worth researching. What global factors explain state failure?

Second, a *theoretical convergence* puzzle is when one body of literature is used to weigh in on another, unrelated body of literature. For example, in asking why criminal groups supply illicit services for themselves and purchase others from illicit markets, Dick (1995) applies the literature on transaction costs to the literature on organized crime. Similarly, in asking why some illicit markets are coercive while others are not, Koivu (2016) applies the literature on anarchic private property rights regimes to illicit markets.

Third, *squaring the circle* puzzles pit contradictory theoretical arguments against one another and look to identify an alternative approach to understanding particular phenomena. For instance, in the literature on development, some argue that nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) undermine democracy and supplant local government service provision (Torpey-Saboe 2015), while others argue that NGOs facilitate interaction between government and society and improve the quality of democracy (Boulding 2014). Which is correct? Nelson-Nunez (2018) “squares the circle” by arguing that NGOs have countervailing effects that are a function of NGO-saturation and the local information environment.

Theoretical puzzles require a sophisticated understanding of theory, but lend themselves nicely to generating testable hypotheses and, more practically, writing a literature review. With this type of approach, however, it can be difficult to find cases that are appropriate for testing those hypotheses. Furthermore, if an appropriate case is found, it may not be feasible for the researcher to study, perhaps due to problems of language or access – the student may discover that the Ottoman Empire is the appropriate case to test their hypothesis, but unfortunately does not read Ottoman Turkish. Here students can start with a literature review, then move to hypothesis generation, and then search for appropriate cases. Hypothesis generation connects the literature review with case selection by forcing the student to distill larger theoretical observations into pointed questions with empirical implications. To select cases, the student should cast a net widely, and investigate multiple cases using plausibility probes – preliminary studies used to determine if more extensive testing is justified (George and Bennett 2005, 75). Or, the student could be encouraged to use a threshold rule: identifying characteristics of the ideal case, and then selecting one that fits those characteristics and is feasible to study (Koivu and Hinze 2017).

Methodological puzzles

Methodological puzzles identify an ongoing debate or an intractable issue to which a particular method has not yet been applied. As such, these puzzles require a high level of methodological literacy at the outset, and are not for the faint of heart.

Here we distinguish two types of methodological puzzles. First, a *measurement* puzzle is when one finds a new way to measure a particularly difficult concept. For instance, Fariss (2014) notes that, according to indicators of repression, human rights practices seem to have not improved over the last half century. Why not? With new measurements utilizing big data, Fariss shows that the increase in observed human rights abuses is in fact due to better recording, not an increase in abuses themselves.

Second, a *technique* puzzle is when one attempts to resolve an intractable issue by applying a new method. For instance, resistance to market reforms in Latin America has often been studied using large-*N* analysis. Though this can identify general trends, it cannot identify idiosyncratic features of each case. What is missing from previous analyses? Simmons (2016) uses comparative ethnography to identify the sources of meaning market reforms have for indigenous communities, and why some market reforms spur resistance while others do not.

Methodological puzzles naturally lead with methods for hypothesis generation and testing, and can capitalize on a researcher's unique skill set. Measurement puzzles in particular focus the researcher's attention on concept formation/operationalization. However, students should begin with the relevant literature before concept formation and case selection. Reviewing the literature lets the researcher recognize the limits of existing explanations, and may lead to a more refined concept, as well as ideas for case selection that re-test previous empirical applications.

Additionally, methodological puzzles are useful with emerging methods that have strengths conventional methods lack. Qualitative comparative analysis (QCA), for instance, is suited for studying conjunctural causation, an improvement over regression-based approaches to interaction effects. Researchers can build on this by identifying poorly understood conjunctural phenomena, and use existing literature to retest hypotheses using new QCA techniques.

Teaching puzzles

Bringing a puzzle-based approach into the classroom involves three steps—a preparatory homework assignment, and a lecture and group exercise that instructors can implement in one class session. First, require students to come to class with a “raw” research question based on their topic of interest. Start class by informally asking students to share them. This initial reservoir of questions provides a baseline for the second step, which is to explain the different types of puzzles to students—empirical, theoretical, and methodological—with concrete examples. Encourage students to think about reframing their initial question with distinct language such as: *What factors explain X? Why did event Z occur in one case and not another?* This teaching exercise primes students for the final step, which is a group activity that helps them further develop skills in identifying puzzles and rendering them into proper research questions (see handout in the Appendix).

Conclusion: Why discovery can precede inquiry

Empirical, theoretical, and methodological puzzles are useful tools for any student in formulating a research question. Above all, anchoring a research question in a puzzle-based approach creates a solid foundation for later stages of research design. Empirical puzzles capitalize on a researcher's preset empirical knowledge and are likely to be the most accessible to undergraduates. These puzzles make clear from the outset the cases that should be selected but need special attention at the concept formation stage to connect the question with the appropriate literature. Theoretical puzzles, on the other hand, come ready-made for situating a research question within the prevailing literature,

but can make case selection difficult, especially when practical constraints of field access in terms of security or language come into play. Both empirical and theoretical puzzles are useful for identifying an appropriate methodology, while methodological puzzles can help test-drive emerging methodological techniques provided they do not become “a method for all seasons.” Such opportunities to develop and extend the puzzle-based approach can only be possible if social science research instruction considers the logic of discovery as a legitimate basis for research design.

Appendix: From Topic to Question Worksheet

In **Class Assignment:** From Topic to Question

Before coming to class students will be expected have done background reading on a particular research topic. In class, students will get into pairs for a series of timed, 5- or 10-minute rounds of discussion. After each round, students will switch partners.

ROUND ONE (5 minutes). What is your topic?

Students will describe the research topic that interests them (e.g., child soldiers, civil war in Yemen, etc.).

ROUND TWO (5 minutes). What about this topic interests you?

Choose from one of the following:

- A. Is it a real-world event or process?
- B. Is it a set of theories or theoretical debates about these events?
- C. Is it a particular method that measures these events?

ROUND THREE (10 minutes). Why is this a puzzle?

Consider your choice above: **A**, **B**, or **C**. This choice will now determine what kind of puzzle you are identifying (empirical, theoretical, methodological, respectively). Now consider the following:

- 1. If you answered above that you are interested in a real-world event or a process (A):
 - a. Is there something unusual or unexpected about it?
 - b. Do similar units experience different outcomes? Do different units experience similar outcomes?
 - c. Does it represent a sudden change or variation over time?
- 2. If you answered above that you are interested in a set of theories or theoretical debates (B):
 - a. Is there an existing literature that can be applied to a new phenomenon?
 - b. Are there different literatures not in dialogue with one another but could be?
 - c. Is there an unreconciled disagreement between explanations for a phenomenon?
- 3. If you answered above that you are interested in a particular method (C):
 - a. Is there a method that could provide a better way to measure a given concept?
 - b. Is there a technique that could provide an alternative way to understand a given phenomenon?

FINAL ROUND (10 minutes). What is your research question?

Partners will discuss their puzzles and together develop each into a research question. They will then decide which question they want to present to the class. After the presentations, the class will vote on which project they would “fund” based on the students’ ability to describe the kind of puzzle that generated the question, and if the question is posed properly. The outcome of this exercise will form the basis of a semester-long research project that seeks to answer the research question by situating it in a broader literature, by developing a hypothesis, and by gathering data.

Notes

1. For concept formation and measurement, see Adcock and Collier (2001), Collier and Levitsky (1997), Collier and Mahon (1993), and Goertz (2006). For case selection, see Collier and Mahoney (1996), Geddes (1990), and Seawright and Gerring (2008). For cross-case analysis, see Elman (2005), Locke and Thelen (1995), Mahoney (2000), and Skocpol and Somers (1980). For within-case analysis, see Beach and Pedersen (2013), George and Bennett (2005), Gerring (2007), and Tetlock and Belkin (1996).

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